translation of *Manimekalai* was the last of the translations of the three surviving Tamil epics undertaken by that great scholar Swaminatha Iyer.

*Manimekalai* shows Nagapattinam to have been as much a mixing-bowl of competing ideas as it was an international marketplace, largely because of its strong trade links with China and Lanka. Innumerable Buddhist teachers and students passed through the city as they came and went between Lanka and the mainland, among them four outstanding Pali scholars of the fifth century each of whom made significant contributions to Buddhist learning: Buddhadatta, Buddhaghosa, Dinnaga and Dhammapala, all of them Tamils writing in Pali rather than Sanskrit, and all promoters of Theravada Buddhism.

However, even these great teachers have to give pride of place to the South Indian guru who became known as Bodhidharma, famous for his trademark unblinking stare, hairy eyebrows and even hairier chest – the monk credited as the founder of Zen Buddhism and kung fu. Chinese Buddhists came to regard Bodhidharma as one of the most important of the early propagators of Mahayana Buddhism, and most of what we know about him comes from those sources, among them a Chinese monk who provided a brief biography of his master in a book on the core teachings of Zen Buddhism. 'The Dharma Master was a South Indian of the Western Region,' he wrote. 'He was the third son of a great Indian king. His ambition lay in the Mahayana path, and so he put aside his white layman's robe for the black robe of a monk … He subsequently crossed distant mountains and seas, travelling about propagating the teaching in Han and Wei.'[13] Another Chinese account makes Bodhidharma the third son of a great king of South India who was a Brahmin. This suggests Pallavan ancestry, since the Pallavas were unusual in claiming Brahmin status, in